

HUM 2101: Sociology and Disaster Management

Social research methods and key sociology terms

Lecture 5.3

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Participant Observation

- Researchers join people and participate in a group's routine activities for the purpose of observing them within that context.
- This method lets researchers experience a specific aspect of social life.
- A researcher might go to great lengths to get a firsthand look into a trend, institution, or behavior.
- A researcher might work as a waitress in a diner, experience homelessness for several weeks, or ride along with police officers as they patrol their regular beat.



Ethnography

- **Ethnography** is the immersion of the researcher in the natural setting of an entire social community to observe and experience their everyday life and culture.
- The heart of an ethnographic study focuses on how subjects view their own social standing and how they understand themselves in relation to a social group.



Experiments

- One way researchers test social theories is by conducting an **experiment**, meaning they investigate relationships to test a hypothesis—a scientific approach.
- There are two main types of experiments: lab-based experiments and natural or field experiments.
 - In a lab setting, the research can be controlled so that more data can be recorded in a limited amount of time.
 - In a natural or field-based experiment, the time it takes to gather the data cannot be controlled but the information might be considered more accurate since it was collected without interference or intervention by the researcher.



Secondary Data Analysis

- While sociologists often engage in original research studies, they also contribute knowledge to the discipline through secondary data analysis.
- Secondary data does not result from firsthand research collected from primary sources, but are the already completed work of other researchers or data collected by an agency or organization.
- Sociologists might study works written by historians, economists, teachers, or early sociologists.
- They might search through periodicals, newspapers, or magazines, or organizational data from any period in history.

